adopted an avowedly Islamicate public presence, as they were increasingly distinguishable from the many transhumant or/and nomadic groups of the region. Implicit within this change of status was their ability to command greater resources, some of which they dedicated to proclaiming their religious affiliation, albeit on a scale and in a context that was still far from the cosmopolitan currents of the Persianate world.

Such a seemingly momentous and certainly consequential change of lifeways and economies is by no means implausible. Among modern nomadic populations of the Iranian world, it is important to note that the variations between nomadism and sedentism can exist both *between* affiliated or related groups, as well as *within* a single one, so that some members are *more* sedentist than their transhumant and nomadic kinsmen or others. Increasing association with settled or urban localities and sedentarization can take place for diametrically opposed reasons, namely, the accumulation of surplus capital and purchase of land; or decline in fortune and ultimate impoverishment, requiring employment by villagers or other settled groups. Once undertaken, the process can be furthered by the already *more* sedentist co-members of a group, who would provide their transhumant or *more* nomadic comrades and kinsmen with ready village or urban connections for labor opportunities, and sale or purchase of supplementary or luxury goods.[75] Such a process could have unfolded at Qalaʿ-yi Zarmurgh, as the Shansabanis' initiated their transition toward a lifestyle *less* of seasonal transhumance, and *more* of an imperial formation with seasonal "capitals."

A question requiring focused discussion with regard to the early coalescence of the Shansabanis is that of Islamization. Scholarly consensus on Ghur's Islamization has been that the region's inhabitants were largely hemmed in by a difficult, mountainous geography resisting both integration into wider commercial networks and the proselytism of Islam (or any other widely dispersed socio-religious system), probably until the eleventh-century Ghaznavid campaigns there.[76] Prior to this period, "the paganism of Ghur was of an indigenous variety and without outside connections."[77] But probably by the early decades of the twelfth century, the Shansabanis' seemingly sudden patronage of Da Qadi's *minar* – an architectural form distinctly evoking Perso-Islamicate culture (if not Islamic ritual) – requires a more nuanced explanation than the homogenizing and ultimately nondescript framework of "Islamization." If the Shansabanis required a transregional mercantile ethos and accompanying religious culture for furthering their political and economic ambitions, why not emulate the numerous Jewish mercantile communities throughout Afghanistan and convert to Judaism, as did the ninth-century Khazars north of the Caspian Sea? Islam was not the only choice.[78]

An important consideration must be brought to bear on the Shansabanis' apparently instantaneous espousal of Islam: perhaps it was not altogether